Assessment of Ghana's 2016 General Election

A Time–Cost–Scope Evaluation

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Framing the Analysis: The Iron Triangle

Time (Schedule)

Meeting constitutional deadlines and avoiding delays.

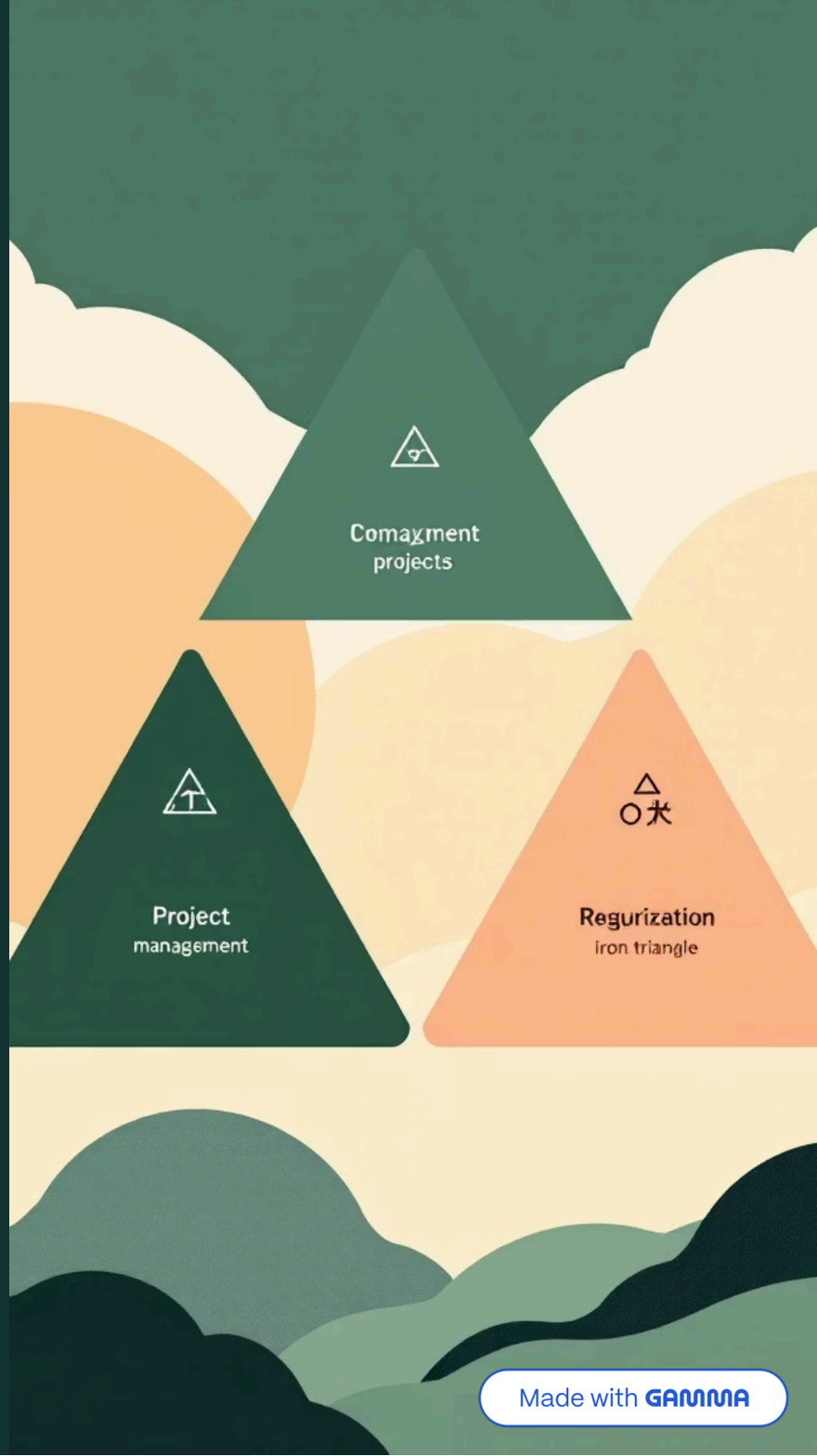
Cost (Budget)

Managing expenses within allocated resources.

Scope & Quality

Achieving participation and public trust targets.

This presentation evaluates Ghana's 2016 General Election strictly as a **project**, using the classic **Iron Triangle** of project management. If *any* constraint is not fully met, the project is classified as a failure.



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Project Overview: Election as a National Endeavor

Project: Ghana 2016 General Election
Implementing Body: Electoral Commission of Ghana
Stakeholders: 15.7 million registered voters, political parties, observers, state institutions
Objective: Conduct a timely, cost-effective election with high national participation and public trust.

The election was a monumental national project with diverse stakeholders and critical objectives for democratic governance.

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Time (Schedule) Performance: FAILED

- Constitutional requirement for national results declaration was met.
- However, voting and/or collation experienced **delays in multiple constituencies**.
- Extended voting into the next day in some areas due to logistical failures.
- Logistical failures (equipment breakdowns, late materials, biometric issues) severely disrupted the schedule.

> **Project Management Verdict:** Under a strict "100% on-time" rule, *any* localized delay counts as schedule failure, regardless of overall completion.

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Cost (Budget) Performance: FAILED

- **Per-voter cost:** over USD 12, an amount publicly described as **"excessive"** by the Electoral Commission Chair.
- **Expenditure increase:** Approximately **85% increase** in goods and services compared to the 2013–2014 electoral cycle.
- **Budget gaps:** Spending significantly exceeded planned allocations, necessitating **supplementary funding** from the government.

> **Project Management Verdict:** Costs substantially exceeded acceptable thresholds and original budget envelopes, indicating a clear budget failure.

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Scope & Quality Performance: FAILED

15.7M	10.9M	70%
Registered Voters	Actual Voters	Voter Turnout
The total number of eligible voters.	Total participants in the election.	Percentage of registered voters who participated.

Analysts and observers referenced **~80% turnout** as an informal success benchmark. The actual turnout fell short by over **10 percentage points**, indicating a failure to meet expected participation scope.

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Scope & Quality (Continued): Participation Gaps

High Turnout Regions

e.g., Ashanti Region

Low Turnout Regions

e.g., parts of Brong-Ahafo

These disparities reveal **uneven national engagement**. While no major legal barriers to voting were reported, the shortfall is attributed to voter apathy, logistical frustrations, and public dissatisfaction. High spending **did not translate** into proportionate gains in turnout or trust.

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Quality & Public Trust: A Critical Scope Dimension

- Observer reports consistently emphasized that **fiscal indiscipline weakened public confidence**.
- Integrity and trust are core quality deliverables for any electoral project.
- Excessive cost without visible quality improvement undermines perceived value and legitimacy.

> **Project Insight:** Delivering outputs (polling nationwide) is not the same as delivering outcomes (confidence, participation, legitimacy).

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Integrated Iron Triangle Summary: Overall Project Failure

Time: Failed

Localized delays meant the schedule was not fully met.

Cost: Failed

Per-voter cost over USD 12; 85% expenditure increase; supplementary funding required.

Scope & Quality: Failed

~70% turnout vs. 80% benchmark; 4.8 million registered voters did not participate; regional disparities and trust concerns.

Overall Assessment: PROJECT FAILURE

Under a strict time–cost–scope framework, all three constraints were breached, qualifying the 2016 General Election as a **project failure** from a project management discipline perspective.

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Key Takeaways for System Analysts

1

Legal Success ≠ Project Success

Meeting legal mandates does not guarantee effective project execution or optimal outcomes.

2

Cost Efficiency Matters

Resource management is as crucial as legitimacy in electoral administration.

3

Expenditure Needs Measurable Gains

High spending must translate into tangible improvements in quality, participation, and trust.

4

Elections as Repeatable Systems

Treat elections as ongoing national systems for continuous improvement, not isolated events.

Sources:

- Electoral Commission of Ghana, *Post-Election Reports & Public Statements (2016)*
- Ghana Statistical Service, *Voter Registration and Turnout Data*
- Institute of Democratic Governance (IDEG), *Election Cost and Integrity Assessments*
- Afrobarometer, *Ghana Public Trust and Participation Surveys*
- World Bank Governance & Public Expenditure Reviews (Ghana)
- Domestic & International Observer Mission Reports (ECOWAS, Commonwealth, EU)

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